



Day of infamy: Brazil exited the tournament before the quarterfinals for the first time since 1990. REUTERS

Raphinha and Lucas Paqueta, both first-team regulars, picked up injuries midway through the tournament.

Meanwhile, Endrick, one of the most promising teenagers in global football, got only 111 minutes across four matches. Bruno Guimaraes, despite having fewer penalty goals for his club last season than Vinicius Jr., took Brazil's spot kick, which was saved by Orjan Nyland.

"Every time he (Endrick) came into this tournament, he brought energy, aggression, and unpredictability. Yet he spent most of the World Cup on the bench. I do not understand that," Ronaldo added. The erosion was evident. Brazil's joga bonito was missing. The elan of attacking to score and playing to win was what made the Selecao dangerous and, at times, terrifying. That virtue now seems to

have been replaced by caution.

Brazil had 34 per cent possession against Norway, its lowest in a World Cup match since records began in 1966. Norway also had better pass accuracy (91 per cent), more shots on target (5) and more than double the number of passes (653 vs 313). Brazil relied on counter-attacks, ceded possession and was ultimately made to suffer by a younger attack against an ageing defence as the soul of the Canary Yellow withered away from the World Cup.

Part of the blame must fall on Ancelotti, who, despite his illustrious resume, failed to get the act together when it mattered most. Some responsibility must also rest with the players, who squandered two clear goalscoring opportunities, one each through Guimaraes and Endrick.

But heads must roll before it is too late. Brazil had never waited more than 24 years to reclaim the World Cup. The exit in 2026 means its current drought will continue

until 2030.

"If I were the head of the Brazilian Football Association, I would immediately tear up the contract with Ancelotti. There is no reason for him to continue as coach," said an angry Romario, who won the 1994 World Cup with Brazil, on his YouTube channel.

Brazil and Germany, two World Cup titans, have fizzled out as a consequence of poor decision-making.

Germany has already begun its rebuild, replacing Nagelsmann with UEFA Champions League-winning Juergen Klopp.

Brazil, however, is expected to stick with Ancelotti until 2030.

For decades, the World Cup script almost always had Brazil and Germany making deep runs. But in 2026, they were reminded once again that history guarantees nothing.

Unless the two giants rediscover the identities that made them champions, the next script may not feature them at all.